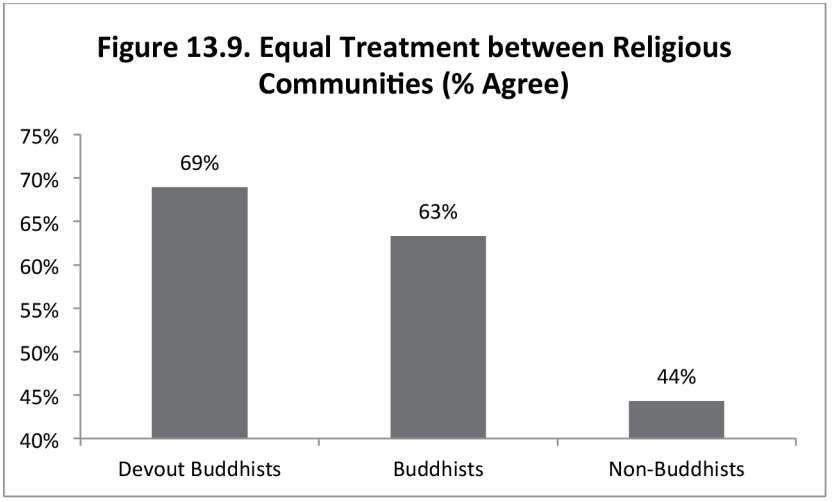


Religion is not a significant factor linked to different perceptions of the economy. Religious minorities express similar views about basic needs, poverty, and economic vulnerability as Buddhists: a majority of both groups are poor and vulnerable. While the hate speech towards religious minorities, especially Muslims, often suggests they hold a favorable economic position, the ABS findings do not suggest religious minorities have considerably more economic security than Buddhists. Forty-five per cent of non-Buddhists stated that their income did not cover the needs, compared to fifty-one per cent of Buddhists. In fact, when asked about income distribution, religious minorities reported a more negative view of fairness in income distribution than Buddhists (eighty-five per cent compared to seventy-eight per cent).

Religious minorities in Myanmar have a less positive view of conditions overall when compared to the majority, showing similar trends to those for ethnic minorities. Given that ethnic and religious minority identities often coincide, this is not surprising. At the same time, Buddhists, especially devout Buddhists, expressed stronger views about intolerance and the role of religion in political life, which has the potential to limit the rights of religious minorities and contribute to conflict.

A closer look at the responses of Buddhists reveals that it is not only in the area of the economy that they have common outlooks with non-Buddhists. Buddhists share a commitment to democracy with citizens of other religions, and are as likely to support a more inclusive and democratic